

person's name on them or give them access, Fast said. Don't feel badly about this. Be your own stopgap.

Many websites suggest getting a "bipolar buddy" who can check in about your spending if you seem to be acting erratically. When I start talking about redecorating my whole apartment, Allison has already taken on the mantle of telling me no. But maybe it needs to be done in a more official capacity. You can also get out in front of yourself by telling the bank to alert your partner or a friend if they see any unusually large payments. (I never knew this was an option.)

"Manic spending is no different than the hyper-sexuality or anything that comes with mania," Fast said on my podcast. "No frontal lobe. No ability to say I can't afford that. All of that is gone." Mania affects me in other ways too: it makes me super social and highly flirtatious. It scatters my thoughts so I stop and start a million projects (I once wrote sixty pages of a feature film in three days without sleeping). I feel more inclined to drink or do drugs. I can be very fun.

But my definition of fun had to change. I function better when I've had enough sleep, food, and time to myself. I'm safer and less inclined to kamikaze my relationships. I actually finish projects I'm working on. I don't spend the next few days feeling sick.

Yet despite all its debilitating effects, mental illness is romanticized. Ernest Hemingway would starve himself, drink a ton of whiskey, and get inspiration from the paintings at the Louvre. How about the numerous biographies I've read on the manic-depressive artist Vincent van Gogh, who could see the vibrant colors of his work only because of his illness? Could it be that my best work is when I'm sick? (This myth is brilliantly destroyed by comedian Hannah Gadsby in her comedy special "Nanette." Please watch it.) When I relayed this misinformed theory of mine to Fast, she immediately called me on my bullshit: *And how did their lives end? They killed themselves.*

*I'll sleep when I'm dead,* I thought proudly, not realizing I was probably bringing that day closer.

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